



LIFE GOES ON

Take stock and barrel through the lockdown

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The novel Coronavirus pandemic has upended regular life with the whole world going into a lockdown for the sake of social distancing. For many geeks, this is a dream come true. The basement dwelling vampires have turned out to have the most experience for handling this kind of situation. Whether you need to work from home or keep connected with friends and family, we got you covered.

WORKING FROM HOME

The first thing you need to do is to pick a device. If it is possible to drive your office PC home, it is recommended to do so. This is because a proper desktop computer really is the best way to work from home. The increased screen size on the monitor helps in productivity,

especially when it comes to working with spreadsheets. For almost any kind of application, there is more space for the workspace as well as the toolbars, which tend to get increasingly crowded with the smaller screens of laptops. A proper keyboard and a mouse is also much faster for input, with the cramped keyboards of laptops slowing you down. You need at least a 14 inch screen in either case. A desktop PC is also really great for ergonomics, and makes sure that you are sitting in a position that makes you want to work. This also means that you will need to have a suitable chair and table. Slacking it off on a couch or bed might just make you way too comfortable to work.

In case a desktop PC is not available, then a laptop is the next best thing. The good thing about laptops is

that they give you flexibility, allow you to move around the house, and for example, continue to work while cooking by plonking the laptop on the kitchen table (make sure to keep it away from the stove though). If all of these are not available, it is just about possible to use a smartphone or a tablet, but then it makes sense to, at the very least, invest in a bluetooth keyboard. Irrespective of whether you are using a laptop or a PC as your primary WFH device, it is important to invest in a number of other things to comfortably work from home. A good headset with a mic, as well as a webcam are both important for video conferencing and talking to colleagues. It is better to invest in a better quality webcam even if your laptop comes with an inbuilt camera. The quality of internet over LAN cable will always be better than WiFi, so that is something that you should consider. Keeping your laptop also wired helps make sure that you stay in one place and don't move around too much.

Just like colleagues can, at times, be a distraction in the office, at home, it is possible that your family members or even yourself can be the biggest distraction. For these reasons, it is necessary to cultivate certain habits to ensure that you are in the correct frame of mind to focus and get the work done. Make sure to inform anyone else living in the house not to disturb you while you are working. Make space for a work area, from where you work every day. Every morning, pretend that there is a small commute from your bed to your desk. Also, make sure to schedule your tasks everyday. For most people, it actually takes longer to get things done while working from home than when they are in office, because they have nowhere else to go at the end of the day, especially during a lockdown. There are a number of applications that help you keep distractions away, and also make you more productive (see box on the next page). It is also a good idea to plan for the next day before wrapping up, so that you can hit the ground running as soon as you wake up.

With the right apps and approaches, it is actually possible to increase your productivity while working from home. Airtasker conducted a study of roughly